



Reasons Behind Students' Preferences for Specific Food Delivery Apps in the U.S.

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Overview



Research topic and motivation



Target audience



Literature review highlights



Research question and hypotheses



Survey design and measures



Key findings (descriptive & inferential)



Implications and future research



Topic & Motivation

Examines college students' use and preferences for food delivery apps.

- Uber Eats, DoorDash, Fantuan, HungryPanda, etc.

These apps are popular among students with busy schedules or limited cooking access.

Selected because these platforms are widely used within our peer networks.

Identifies key drivers and barriers behind student consumption and digital decision-making.

Why This Research Matters



Student reliance

Students use delivery apps for convenience, busy schedules, and accessible food options.



Mixed Motivations

Finances, living situations, and cultural needs influence both adoption and avoidance.



Better app design

Understanding cost, usability, and service quality helps improve student-centered features.



Target Audience

College students aged 18–25 in the U.S.

- Frequently rely on mobile technology for daily tasks
- Includes both domestic and international students
- Diverse in racial backgrounds and culinary needs
- Students with differing financial constraints shaping app use behavior.



Literature Review

01

Adoption Drivers

Inconsistent eating patterns and limited kitchen access increase reliance on delivery services

03

Service Quality

Delivery speed, order accuracy, restaurant variety, and easy app interfaces strongly influence satisfaction and continued use

02

Cost Sensitivity

Tight budgets and financial disparities make students highly price-conscious, actively seeking discounts and switching apps for deals

04

Social Influence

Peer recommendations and social media exposure significantly shape awareness, preferences, and situational use of delivery apps

Research Question

What factors most strongly influence college students' preferences for specific food delivery apps in the United States?

Main factors examined:

Cost sensitivity

Perceived service quality

App usability

Social influence

Cultural and demographic differences

Hypotheses

H1

Higher levels of cost sensitivity are associated with stronger preferences for specific food delivery apps.

H2

Perceived service quality (especially delivery speed and customer service) is positively associated with usage frequency.

H3

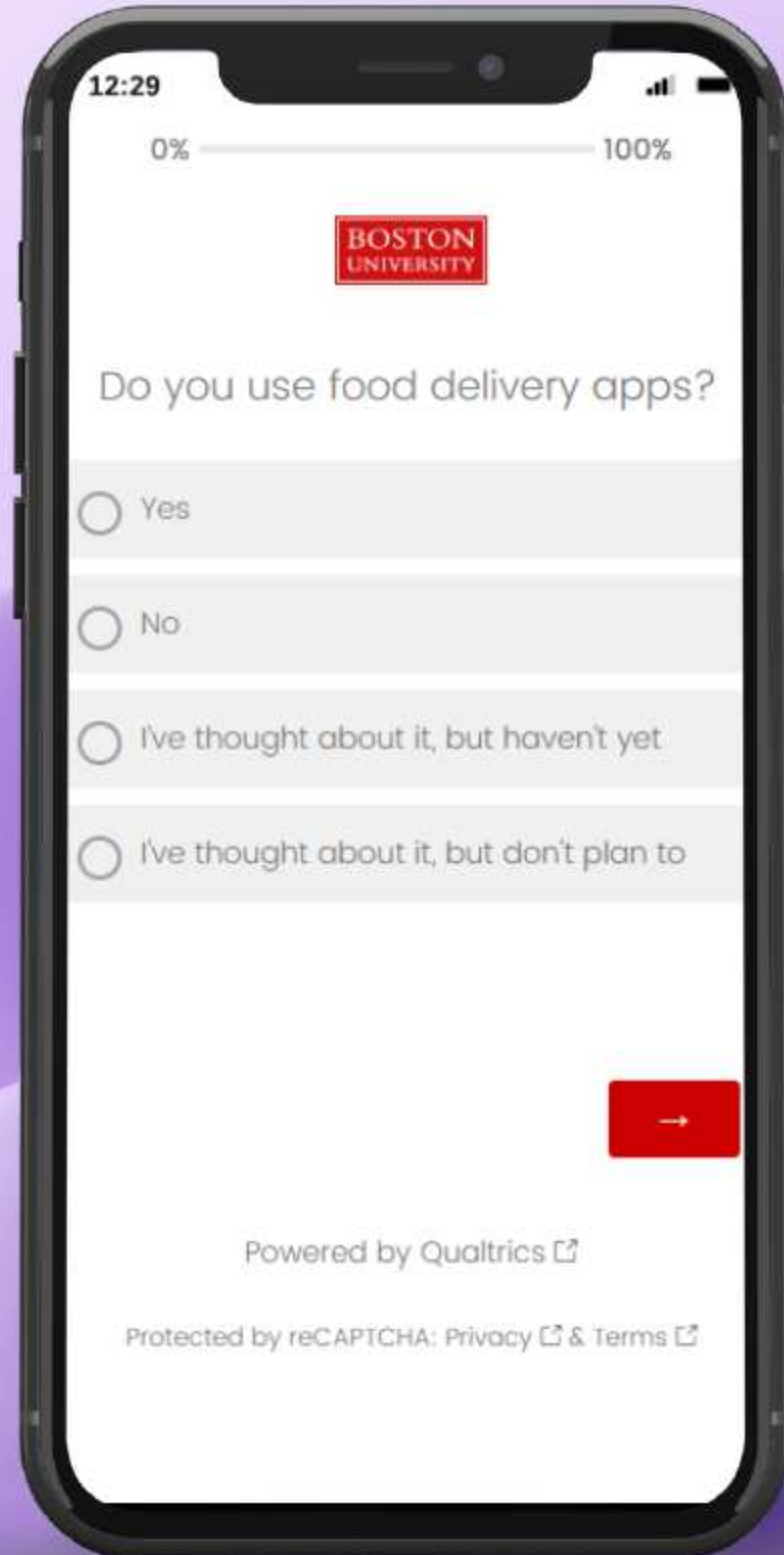
Students who prioritize app usability and stability are more likely to prefer mainstream platforms (e.g., Uber Eats, DoorDash).

H4

Social influence (peer recommendations, social media exposure) positively predicts adoption and regular use.

H5

International and racially minoritized students are more likely to rely on delivery apps due to challenges accessing culturally familiar foods.



Survey Development

Designed in Qualtrics

Comprehensive Measurement

- Adoption patterns and frequency
- Platform preferences
- Decision factors (price, speed, variety)
- Information sources
- Barriers and difficulties
- Qualitative experiences

Question Types

- Multiple choice
- Multi-select options
- 5-point Likert scales
- Open-ended responses

Survey Development

Adoption & non-use: Q1, Q1a

- Identify users vs. non-users
- Reasons for non-use (cost, familiarity, etc.)

App preference & frequency: Q2, Q3

- Primary platform used
- Weekly ordering frequency

Decision factors & importance: Q4, Q5

- Price, delivery time, app performance, customer service, food variety
- 5-point Likert scales for importance

Social influence & challenges: Q6, Q7

- Sources of information
- Difficulties (cost, lack of familiar food, interface, language)

Qualitative insights: Q8, Q9

- Cross-country comparisons
- Positive/negative experiences



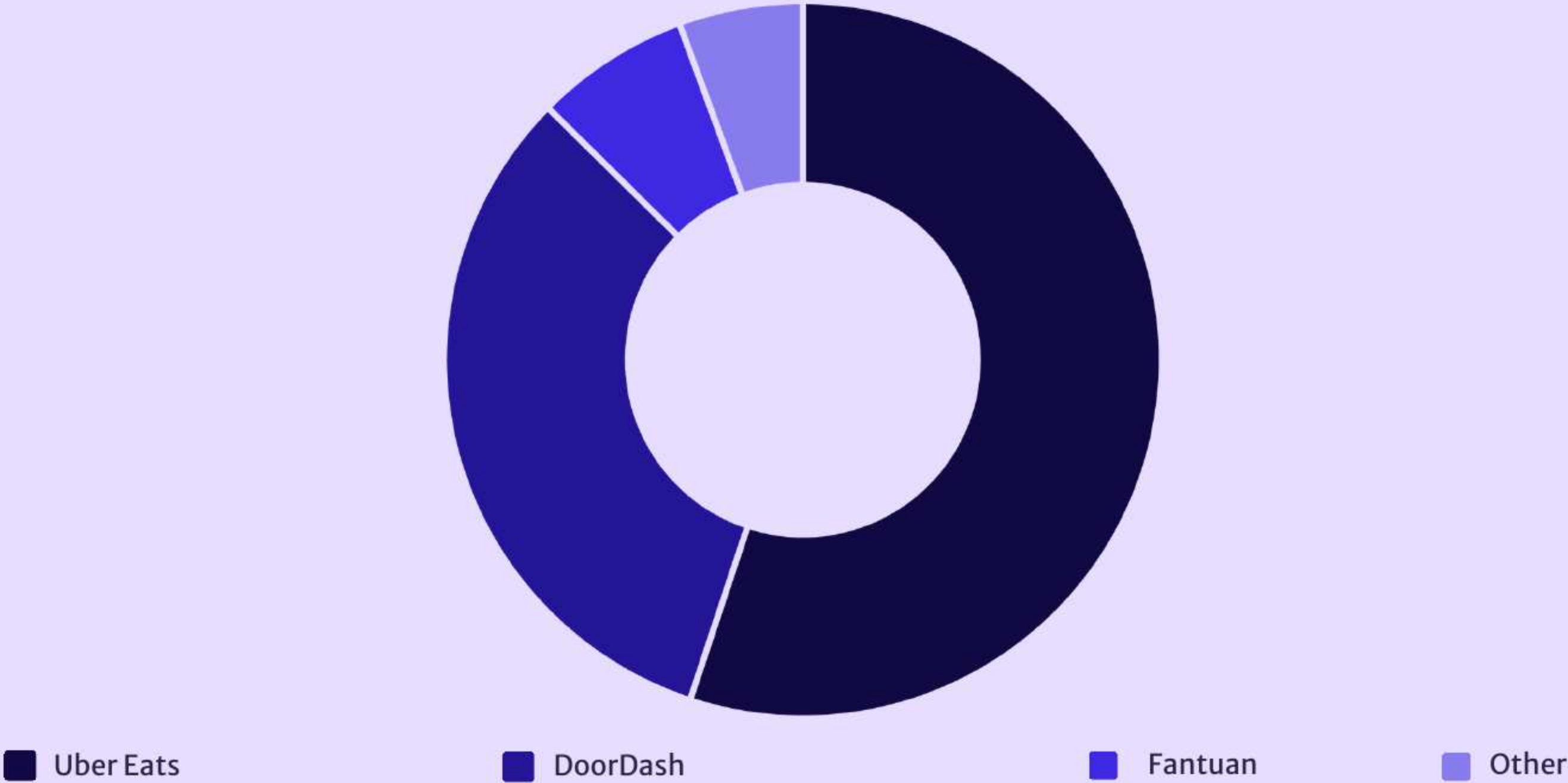
Platform Preferences

Market heavily concentrated in two major platforms, with smaller services capturing minimal share

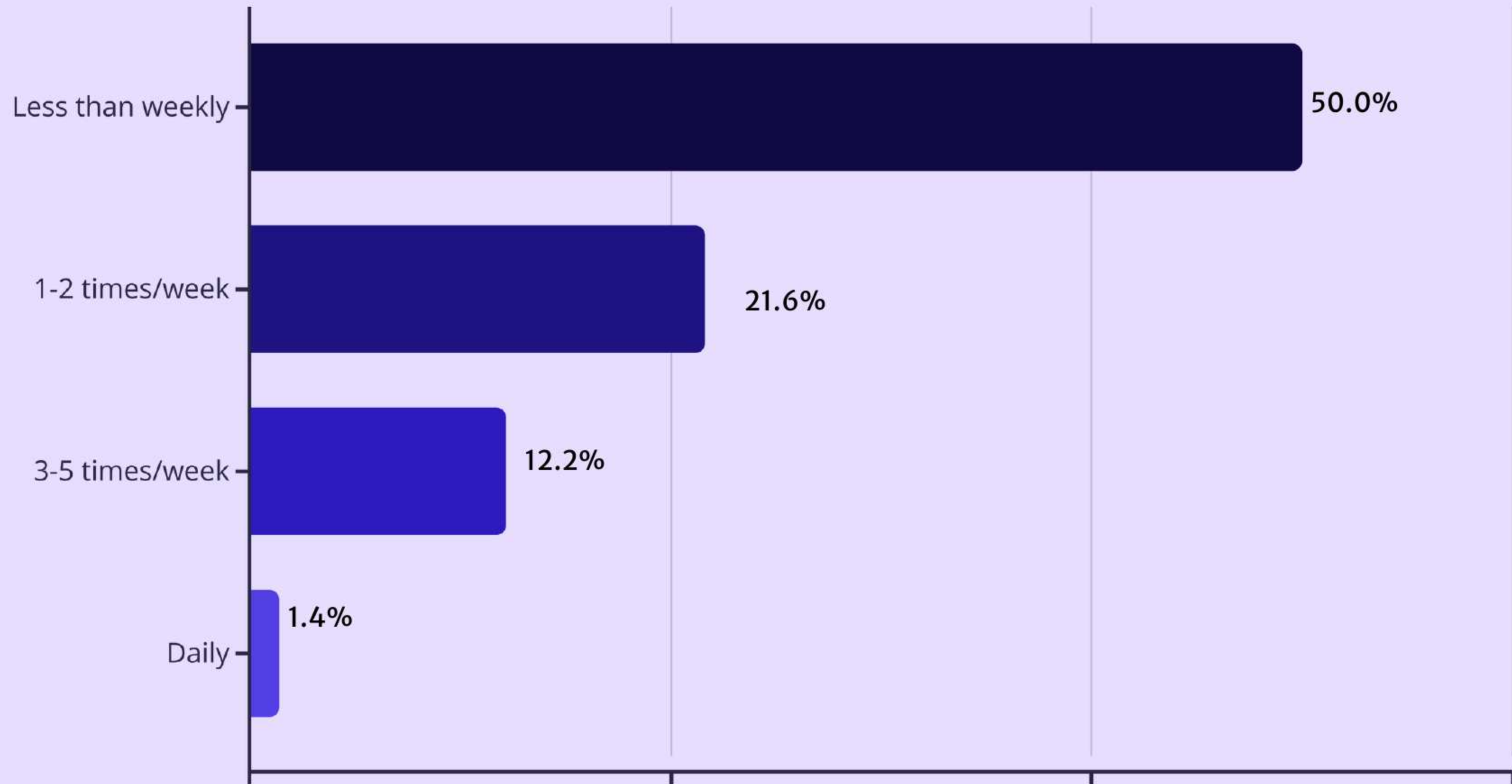
83.1%
Active Users
Currently use food delivery apps

55.4%
Uber Eats
Most popular platform choice

32.4%
DoorDash
Second most preferred app



Ordering Frequency



Half of students order less than once weekly—suggesting cost and other barriers limit usage even among active users

Key Decision Factors

Most influential decision factors (multi-select):



Importance ratings (means):

Delivery fees
M = 4.41 (SD = 0.95)

Promotions/discounts
M = 4.28

Food variety
M = 4.12

Delivery time
M = 4.01

Customer service
M = 3.89



Information Sources & Barriers

Information sources for apps or promotions:

- Friends/other students: 35.1%
- Social media (WeChat, Xiaohongshu, TikTok, Instagram): 27.0%
- Advertisements: 31.1%
- Campus events: 1.4%
- Other: 5.4%

Main barriers/difficulties (Q7):

- High prices: 94.1%
- Lack of Chinese food options: 20.6%
- Complicated interfaces: 7.4%
- Language barriers: 2.9%



Inferential Results:

App Preference & Food Availability

Question: Is app preference associated with perceived lack of Chinese food options?

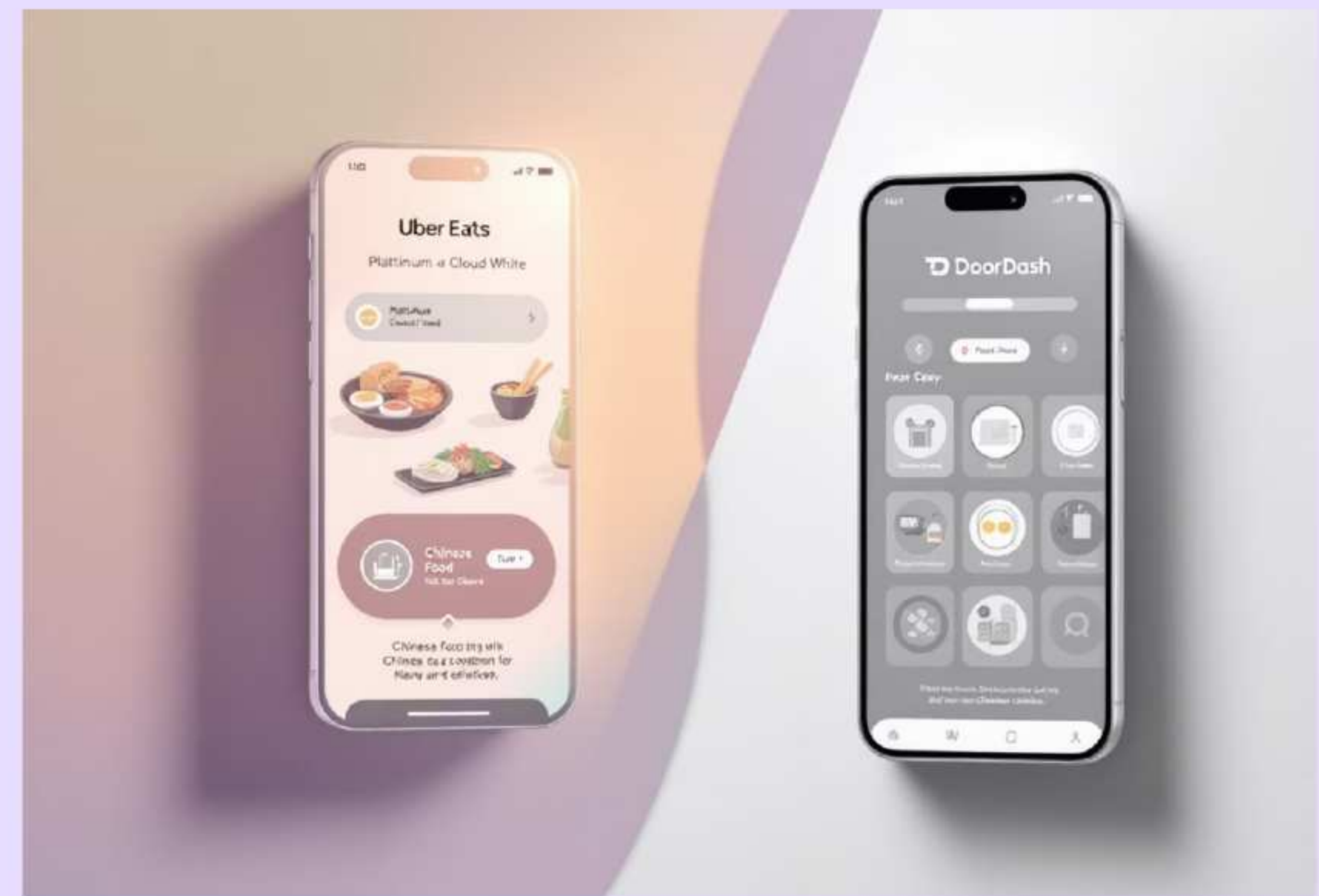
Chi-square test:

$$\chi^2(1, N = 57) = 3.76, p = .053$$

- trend-level, not statistically significant

Pattern observed:

- Uber Eats users more likely to report limited Chinese food options
- DoorDash users rarely mention this issue
Suggests possible platform differences in perceived cuisine availability



DoorDash Users

White participants tended to prefer DoorDash

Uber Eats Users

Asian participants overwhelmingly preferred Uber Eats.

Key Takeaways for Platforms

Cost is the dominant concern:

- Consider student discounts, reduced delivery fees, or student membership plans

Market concentrated in two major platforms (Uber Eats & DoorDash):

- Strategic improvements here can have the greatest impact

Platform recommendations:

- Expand culturally relevant restaurant options
- Improve cuisine filters/search for Asian and other ethnic foods
- Use referral programs, campus ambassadors, and partnerships with student groups



Implications for Future Research

Explore how:

Financial Stress & Food Insecurity

Financial stress and food insecurity shape delivery habits

Cultural Background

Cultural background affects expectations of food availability

Living Arrangements

Living arrangements (kitchen access, dining hall usage) influence ordering frequency

Use qualitative methods (e.g., interviews) to:

- Understand dissatisfaction with fees
- Compare experiences between U.S. and home-country delivery services

Key Insights



Cost Drives Behavior

High delivery fees and service charges are the strongest barriers. Students use apps widely but order infrequently due to cost pressure.



Two-Platform Market

Uber Eats + DoorDash dominate usage (85%+), showing a highly concentrated market among college students.



Cultural Food Matters

International and Asian students rely more on delivery apps to access familiar foods, yet often report limited culturally relevant options.



Social Influence Shapes Awareness

Friends, roommates, and social media are the main sources of information, driving app adoption and promo awareness.



Usability Supports Convenience

Smooth app interface, stable performance, and quick checkout enhance student experience but are not the top priority compared to price.

CONCLUSION

The study shows that cost concerns and cultural food needs strongly shape students' choices of food delivery platforms.

Students use these apps widely, but overall ordering frequency remains low due to high fees.

Platform preferences differ across student groups, reflecting diverse expectations and experiences.

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Appendix

Case Processing Summary						
	Valid		Cases Missing		Total	
	N	Percent	N	Percent	N	Percent
Which food delivery app do you use most often in the U.S.? - Selected Choice * What is the main difficulty you encounter when using food delivery apps in the U.S.? (Check all that apply) Lack of Chinese food options	57	100.0%	0	0.0%	57	100.0%

Which food delivery app do you use most often in the U.S.? - Selected Choice * What is the main difficulty you encounter when using food delivery apps in the U.S.? (Check all that apply) Lack of Chinese food options Crosstabulation

Count

What is the main difficulty you encounter when using food delivery apps in the U.S.? (Check all that apply) Lack of Chinese food options			
	Not Selected	Lack of Chinese food options	Total
Which food delivery app do you use most often in the U.S.? - Selected Choice			
User Eats	27	9	36
Don't Eat	20	1	21
Total	47	10	57

Chi-Square Tests

	Value	df	Asymptotic Significance (2-sided)	Exact Sig. (2-sided)	Exact Sig. (1-sided)
Pearson Chi-Square	0.755 ^a	1	.380		
Continuity Correction ^b	2.487	1	.115		
Likelihood Ratio	4.815	1	.026		
Fisher's Exact Test				.074	.052
Linear-by-Linear Association	3.089	1	.076		
N of Valid Cases	57				

a. 1 cells (.5.0%) have expected count less than 5. The minimum expected count is 3.98.

b. Computed only for a 2x2 table

Crosstabs		
Notes		
Output Created	29-NOV-2025 01:20:30	
Comments		
Input	Data	C:\Users\wvck\OneDrive\12\3 final report\CM 722 Class Research Survey Fall 2025_November 11, 2025_15.45.sav
Active Dataset	1	
Filter	(Gender = 1 OR Gender = 2) AND (Race = 1 OR Race = 4) AND (Group1.2 = 1 OR Group1.2 = 2) ...	
Weight	<none>	
Split File	<none>	
N of Rows in Working Data File	57	
Missing Value Handling	Definition of Missing	User-defined missing values are treated as missing
	Cases Used	Statistics for each table are based on all the cases with valid data in the specified range(s) for all variables in each table.
Syntax	CROSSTABS /TABLES=Group1.2 BY Group1.2 /FORMAT=AVALUE TABLES /STATISTICS=CHI2 CORR /CELLS=COUNT /COUNT ROUND CELL	
Resources	Processor Time	00:00:00.02
	Elapsed Time	00:00:00.01
	Dimensions Requested	2
	Cells Available	524245

Case Processing Summary

	Valid		Cases Missing		Total	
	N	Percent	N	Percent	N	Percent
Please select your race/ethnicity. - Selected Choice * Which food delivery app do you use most often in the U.S.? - Selected Choice	57	100.0%	0	0.0%	57	100.0%

Please select your race/ethnicity. - Selected Choice * Which food delivery app do you use most often in the U.S.? - Selected Choice
Crosstabulation

		Which food delivery app do you use most often in the U.S.? - Selected Choice		
		User Eats	DoorDash	Total
Please select your race/ethnicity. - Selected Choice	White	11	18	29
	Asian	20	3	23
Total		36	21	57

Chi-Square Tests

	Value	df	Asymptotic Significance (2-sided)	Exact Sig. (2-sided)	Exact Sig. (1-sided)
Pearson Chi-Square	16.145 ^a	1	<.001		
Continuity Correction ^b	14.015	1	<.001		
Likelihood Ratio	17.409	1	<.001		
Fisher's Exact Test				<.001	<.001
Linear-by-Linear Association	15.863	1	<.001		
N of Valid Cases	57				

a. 0 cells (.00%) have expected count less than 5. The minimum expected count is 10.32.

b. Computed only for a 2x2 table

Crosstabs		
Notes		
Output Created	29-NOV-2025 01:12:01	
Comments		
Input	Data	C:\Users\wvck\OneDrive\12\3 final report\CM 722 Class Research Survey Fall 2025_November 11, 2025_15.45.sav
Active Dataset	1	
Filter	(Gender = 1 OR Gender = 2) AND (Race = 1 OR Race = 4) AND (Group1.2 = 1 OR Group1.2 = 2) ...	
Weight	<none>	
Split File	<none>	
N of Rows in Working Data File	57	
Missing Value Handling	Definition of Missing	User-defined missing values are treated as missing
	Cases Used	Statistics for each table are based on all the cases with valid data in the specified range(s) for all variables in each table.
Syntax	CROSSTABS /TABLES=Race BY Group1.2 /FORMAT=AVALUE TABLES /STATISTICS=CHI2 CORR /CELLS=COUNT /COUNT ROUND CELL	
Resources	Processor Time	00:00:00.02
	Elapsed Time	00:00:00.01
	Dimensions Requested	2
	Cells Available	524245

Symmetric Measures			
		Value	Asymptotic Standard Error ^a
Interval by Interval	Pearson's R	.267	.006
Ordinal by Ordinal	Spearman Correlation	-.257	.006
N of Valid Cases		57	
Symmetric Measures			
		Value	Asymptotic Standard Error ^a
Interval by Interval	Pearson's R	.054 ^c	.006
Ordinal by Ordinal	Spearman Correlation	.054 ^c	.006
N of Valid Cases		57	
a. Not assuming the null hypothesis.			
b. Using the asymptotic standard error assuming the null hypothesis.			
c. Based on normal approximation.			
Symmetric Measures			
		Value	Asymptotic Standard Error ^a
Interval by Interval	Pearson's R	-.532	.106
Ordinal by Ordinal	Spearman Correlation	-.532	.106
N of Valid Cases		57	
Symmetric Measures			
		Value	Asymptotic Standard Error ^a
Interval by Interval	Pearson's R	<.001 ^a	.001
Ordinal by Ordinal	Spearman Correlation	<.001 ^a	.001
N of Valid Cases		57	
a. Not assuming the null hypothesis.			
b. Using the asymptotic standard error assuming the null hypothesis.			
c. Based on normal approximation.			

Thank you